



Riding the momentum: Alexander Zverev backed up his Roland Garros win this year with his second Grand Slam title this US Open. GETTY IMAGES

Five big questions loomed in the men's draw going into the last Slam of 2026. Could seven-time Major champion Carlos Alcaraz regain his elite form after being sidelined for four and a half months with a wrist injury? Was tennis GOAT Novak Djokovic — who played spectacularly to upset Jannik Sinner in an Australian Open five-set semifinal and No. 4 Felix Auger-Aliassime in the Wimbledon quarterfinals, also in five sets — still a bona fide contender at 39? Would former US Open finalist Taylor Fritz, former semifinalists Ben Shelton or Frances Tiafoe, or perhaps No. 14 Learner Tien or No. 19 Tommy Paul become the first American man to win a long-awaited Major title since Andy Roddick in 2003? What about other young talents Arthur Fils, Joao Fonseca, Rafael Jodar, Jakub Mensik, Alexander Blockx and Felix Auger-Aliassime?

And, of course, was Alexander Zverev just another 'one-Slam wonder' or a late-blooming champion like Stan Wawrinka?

The new-and-improved Zverev hit his forehand more aggressively than ever — Rafael Nadal advised him to be 'braver' — and moved faster thanks to a rigorous speed-work programme devised by renowned conditioning coach Jez Green. Even so, the 6ft 6in, broad-shouldered German barely survived the first two rounds. Lorenzo Sonego, a flashy but erratic Italian shot-maker ranked No. 89, was two points away from a huge upset deep in the fourth set before Zverev recovered for a 6-4, 3-6, 6-7(7), 7-5, 6-4 victory. "Lots of ups and downs. This is exactly the match I needed," Zverev said, perhaps prophetically.

The top seed was equally unimpressive against Quentin Halys, a Frenchman ranked No. 52, again barely surviving 6-4, 4-6, 7-6(3), 6-7(3), 6-3 in another marathon that ended around 2 am. "He was super tentative and scared on his forehand," noted Jim Courier. Sascha had already spent 9 hours and 26

minutes competing on court.

Not to worry, because Zverev was in the easier half of the draw, and the rest of the top 16 seeds, except for No. 14 Tien, were blown away by the third round. Karen Khachanov knocked out No. 3 Auger-Aliassime, Blockx overpowered No. 5 Cobolli, the hard-to-pronounce Botić van de Zandschulp straight-setted No. 6 Alex de Minaur, and Francisco Cerundolo outlasted No. 9 Fritz. Meanwhile, Zverev, back in the groove, took care of business in his quarter, outclassing No. 25 Alejandro Tabilo, No. 21 Luciano Darderi and van de Zandschulp, and surrendering only 10, 10 and eight games, respectively.

The real action took place in the bottom half of the draw, where all eyes were on Alcaraz. "I'll look at the speed and spin rate of his forehand," said Courier. Other experts were curious to see if his first serve had lost any of its 130-mph-plus zip.

Carlitos hit the hard courts running with a solid 6-4, 6-4, 6-4 win over Russian journeyman Roman Safiullin, highlighted by a ferocious 107-mph forehand winner. Still wearing a compression sleeve on his right arm and a brown Nike basketball-style shirt, the defending champion found the right level of offence and patience to oust Portuguese standout Jaime Faria 4-6, 6-0, 6-3, 6-2. Then the Charisma Kid engaged the cheering fans with his slingshot celebration.

After Alcaraz demolished lucky loser Wu Yibing, the first Chinese man to reach the third round at the US Open, 6-3, 6-4, 6-1 for his 17th Major win in a row, he assessed his comeback so far. "To be honest, I'm better than I thought [I'd be]. Right now, I think my level is really high." It would need to be against top-notch athlete and dynamic volleyer Tommy Paul, who boasted two hard-court wins over Alcaraz at the Canadian Open.

Alcaraz had never lost to an American at a Major, and the streak continued as he took the action-packed fourth-round duel 6-4, 6-3, 6-4. Alcaraz does everything a little bit better than Paul, especially